thames view





ISSUE 1

YOUR COMMUNITY MAGAZINE

FEBRUARY 05

News Feature

The Chinese Culture and Arts Community Organisation arranged a Christmas Party in the Atrium. With funding provided by EaDiP, (Gallions' Equality and Diversity Panel), guests were treated to a traditional Chinese lion dance, Mongolian dancing and line dancing. With more than 100 guests to cater for, chef Truang Tran had his hands full. A member of the Bexley Council for Racial Equality, Mr Tran provided a fabulous array of food helped by a willing band of volunteers rustled up by Val Honor.



As one of the first events EaDiP has funded it was a great success. Mrs Myers, a Thamesmead resident, says " I don't often get the chance to mix with the Chinese community. It was nice to see their colourful costumes." EaDiP aims to draw together and promote social cohesion among those communities who are often underrepresented. Wendy Mason, Gallions' Resident Involvement Officer, explains how some of the EaDiP budget will be used.

"EaDiP will sponsor activities that promote equal opportunities in Thamesmead while directly benefiting the people of Thamesmead. Additionally, we plan to further deliver the Living Together Action Plan. This may include funding training or additional studies for a particular resident. "

Bringing different groups of people together is an ideal way to share experiences and gain a greater understanding of cultural differences.

The Christmas lunch party is a good example of EaDiP's work in practice. EaDiP is made up from staff, Board members, residents and community groups. Originally, the panel was established to deal with issues affecting black, minority and ethnic residents. Now the group is spreading its wings to include other sections of the community.

If you would like more information or feel you may qualify for EaDiP sponsorship why not pick up the phone and call Wendy Mason 0208 320 3417

TAVY BRIDGE TIMELINE
Keeping up to date with the latest news

WARDENS WATCH
Meeting the people the wardens meet

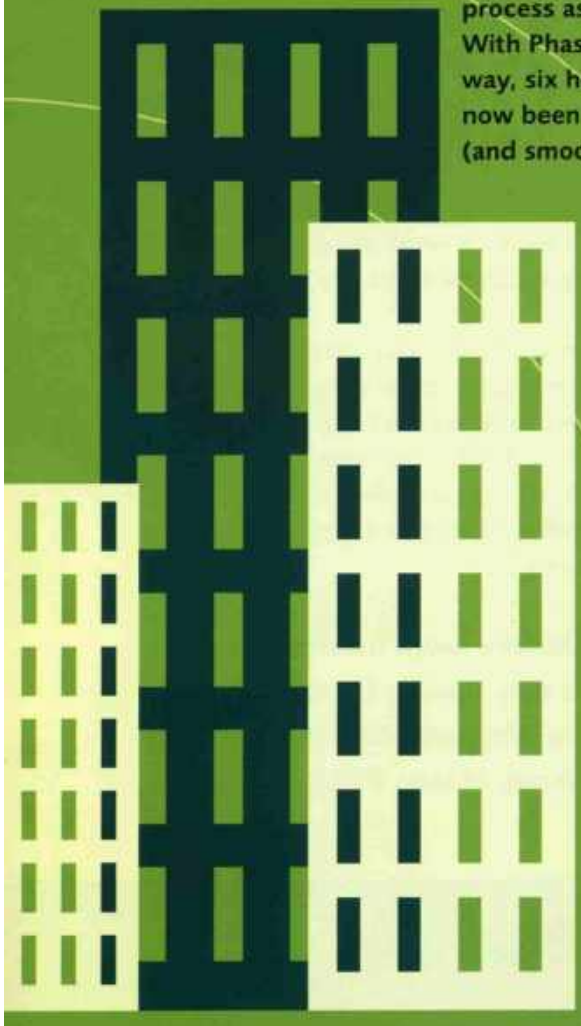
ONE TO ONE
Making a difference to Thamesmead

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

Tavy Bridge Timeline...

On one level, Tavy Bridge is an innovative and ambitious regeneration plan involving many major corporations with big budgets. However, to most of our readers, it is a huge upheaval in their day-to-day lives. While everybody agrees that the regeneration is vital and will bring enormous benefits to Tavy Bridge residents, there are some big changes ahead for many people.

The Re-housing and Lettings team at Gallions is determined to make the whole moving in and out process as smooth as possible. With Phase one well under way, six households have now been successfully (and smoothly) re-located.



Three more households are already in the early stages of the decanting process with a further eight waiting in the pipeline.
In total, 137 households will be moved over the course of this 10-year project. Every effort is made to find residents suitable accommodation – we have even been asked to relocate some to Devon and Bristol. Finding 3 and 4 bedroom houses is more difficult as they are often in short supply. However, we have introduced the Under Occupancy Scheme where those living in properties that are too large for their housing needs are encouraged to relocate.
By keeping residents informed at every stage of the process, helping them choose carpets and curtains, and arranging the re-direction of post, we can help limit stress levels.

We also provide financial support with a home loss payment up to £3,400 and a further fee to cover all reasonable removal and disconnection costs. Residents will not be out of pocket as a result of their relocation. Ideally, it is best to make the whole decanting process happen as quickly as possible. We are pleased to say that the average turnaround time in December was just under four weeks – not bad when you consider all that's involved.

If you are a Tavy Bridge resident and would like to share your experiences with us, please contact the Tavy Bridge Team on 0208 320 3555

ISSUE #1

editorial

Talk of the Town

Nearly everyone starts a new year with new ideas and plans. And we're no different here. Our Newsletter has been around for four years and we thought it needed a bit of a facelift. First of all, we have given it a new name and a new look. Thamesview is about the people and places of Thamemead. It aims to bring you stories and news about what's going on in your community. And, there's a lot to talk about in this town. Putting this issue together we have met many interesting people with stories to tell. They all contribute to the diverse and thriving community that has made Thamesmead what it is today. Thamesview is your magazine and it is important to us that we give you what you want. So, if you have something to say that other residents need to hear why not give the team at Thamesview a call on 0208 320 3414.

And finally, Happy New Year to all our readers.

Equality in Action
Celebrations between the cultures

Tavy Bridge Timeline
What's happening with our big project

Wardens Watch
Out and about with the team

Shared ownership
getting a foot on the property ladder

Changes and choices
it's all change for benefit payments

Green Scene
Easy ways to help save the planet

One to One
Steve Boscic shares his vision





Take a walk with the Wardens

Age Concern

In their bright yellow jackets, the neighbourhood wardens are a familiar sight in and around Thamesmead. Stephen Hayzen, a warden for two years, took us to visit some of the people he meets in his daily rounds.

Elsie Gould is one of a kind. At 84 years old she shows the positive spirit and determination of a woman half her age. Elsie, a Thamemead resident for many years, believes that laughter is the key to staying young – a formula she shared with her husband Jim for 63 years.

"Jim never ran out of things to say. His great sense of humour helped us through some difficult times. We had a special relationship that was based on love and laughter."

Perhaps the most difficult time for Elsie and Jim was when they lost their daughter 15 years ago. But Elsie believes very firmly in looking forward and not back. Today, she enjoys good health and keeps her mind active by taking an interest in current affairs and visiting her community club up to three times a week. A widow for five years now and with no immediate family nearby, Elsie has come to rely on the regular visits she gets from the wardens.

"My friend John and I look forward to spending time with people outside of our circle. They bring us news of what's happening in Thamesmead and are always ready to help should we need it. Both John and I can still get out and about quite easily but it's nice to know that someone is keeping an eye out for you."

While Elsie enjoys the companionship offered by the wardens, other elderly residents depend on them for more practical support. Whatever their needs, Elsie believes that the wardens provide a much needed service for the elderly and vulnerable within Thamesmead.

Now, with the festivities over and Elsie back from a trip to Yorkshire she's looking forward to the New Year with the same upbeat approach that has sustained her throughout her long and interesting life.



More wardens on the way

Such has been the success of the Neighbourhood Warden's scheme that there are plans to extend its range to include South Thamesmead.

A number of new wardens have already been recruited and are undergoing training. Expect to see some new faces on the streets in early February.



Team Gallions

Coming up roses....

Team Gallions is pleased to announce the arrival of 3,200 flowering plants to brighten up the communal walkways and landings of Simon, Shire, Teeswater and Buckwheat Courts, and Harold Wilson House. With the young and old alike agreeing to take care of the plants, 2005 is starting with a big, colourful splash for some residents. However, not everyone is enjoying an attractive view when they step outside their door. While there are many responsible dog owners in Thamesmead, there are also quite a number who do not clean up after their dog. Let's face it, no one likes clearing up dog mess. But looking unsightly is just one of the problems that comes with this most antisocial behaviour. The digested results of just one dog's dinner can cause serious health problems, mainly to young children. 120 dog bins are available in Thamesmead so there is no excuse. FREE, environmentally friendly, "scoop the poop" bags are also available from all Team Gallions Staff and from reception at Harrow Manor Way.

And finally, good humour and good will did prevail over the Christmas period. Thanks to all those residents who put their rubbish down the chute or waited to give it to the dustmen.

Stamping out Anti Social Behaviour

If you would like a copy of Gallions' Anti Social Behaviour procedure you can ask your Housing Co-ordinator or can view and download a copy from the Gallions website www.gallionsha.co.uk

The procedure explains what Anti Social Behaviour is, the steps Gallions takes to stamp out such behaviour and how we support people who have suffered. Changes to the procedures have been made as a result of feedback from tenants and other groups.

If you have any questions or would like to discuss the procedures and how they might affect you please contact your Housing Co-ordinator

Visit our new website www.gallionsha.co.uk

2005 new year new start new challenges

RATHER THAN GIVING SOMETHING UP THIS YEAR WHY NOT TAKE UP SOMETHING NEW INSTEAD



Resourceful Courses

At a recent Taster Day at Gallions' Community Resource Centre, local residents enjoyed complementary classes in IT, Floristry and Hair and Beauty. With 95% of the attendees signing up on the spot to learn new skills, Bexley Adult Education has put together a series of 8 week training courses.
Residents can enrol in a number of different courses and training schemes. Linda Thompson, the Centre's administrator says "the demand for computer classes has been the greatest and accredited courses may even be introduced. With a free crèche at the Resource Centre available in the mornings, this is a great opportunity to learn something new." Courses are starting again in April. If you have any ideas about what course you would like to see, just let us know. **Call Linda on 020 8320 3468 to find out what's available now and later in the year.**

A Marathon Challenge

Are you someone with a big ambition? Do you want to get fit? Do you like running?
If so, Gallions would like to sponsor a Thamesmead resident to participate in the London Marathon. Training, motivation and entering will be up to you but we will support you from the start line to the finish with our sponsorship deal. This includes running gear for the big day and a donation to a local charity of your choice. **We want to hear from you if you want to take up the challenge on 0208 320 3414.**

Community Contact Scheme

Gallions has introduced the Community Contact Scheme for those areas which are not already represented by a Tenants and Residents Association. The scheme aims to provide a clear, two-way line of communication between residents and Gallions. We want to hear about the issues that are important to you and we want to tell you what we are doing to address these issues. Too often problems remain unsolved simply through poor communication – the Community Contact Scheme will help ensure that your voice is heard. **For more information contact Wendy Mason – 0208 320 3417 Email: wmason@gallionsha.co.uk**

Last year Gallions tenant Samantha Bryan made the decision to leave her rented flat and buy a new home with her partner Stewart McKenna. Like many other first time buyers, they knew their joint income just wasn't going to stretch far enough. Here Samantha explains how the part buy, part rent scheme has given her and Stewart the chance to set up home under the Shared Ownership Scheme.



"I lived in my Gallions flat for around 18 months and it was great, but Stewart and I really wanted to get onto the property ladder and build some financial security. The part buy part rent scheme has given us the opportunity to do this. We applied for the scheme after I received some information from the Gallions Sales Team. I was over the moon when we found out that our application had been accepted. We were invited to look around the properties available and found the one we wanted the very same day.

We could afford to buy a 50% share and the sales team arranged for us to see a financial advisor to help us sort out a mortgage. For the remaining 50% we will pay a subsidised rent to Gallions.

The Shared Ownership Scheme is perfect because after the first year we can buy more shares or even buy it outright if we can afford to. If we decide to sell, Gallions have 8 weeks to find someone to buy our share. If they don't find anyone we can either sell our share or the full value on the open market. Whichever way, we will always keep our share of any profit.

Our new apartment comes with carpets throughout, a designer fitted kitchen with oven and hob, a shiny new fitted bathroom, an excellent security system and even an allocated parking space. It is bright and clean and won't even need decorating, which is great news for Stewart!

We have both always lived in Thamesmead and were keen to stay in the area. Not just because our friends and family are here - it's a great opportunity to invest in a new home in what is definitely an up and coming area.

The sales team were always helpful and made the process very easy. I would definitely recommend shared ownership for anyone wanting to own a brand new home and get some long-term financial security.

For further information call 0800 731 4587



The Sales team are giving Gallions' tenants £250 upon completion of the purchase of a shared ownership home.



CHANGES AND CHOICES

April 2005 will see one of the biggest shake-ups in income benefit payments for decades. Gone will be the traditional order books and cheques through the letterbox and in will be direct payments into bank and post office accounts. Big changes are ahead - but don't worry help is at hand.

Anybody who is currently receiving benefit payments has some important decisions to make in the near future.Gallions Housing Association is a member of Change, a partnership of 10 housing associations. Change has launched the Benefits and Banking project to help residents through the new system. Working closely with The Department of Work and Pensions, 37members from the Change partnership have been drafted into the project team. Lesley Edwards is Gallions' team member. Her specialist banking skills will help residents understand what options are available and how the changes will affect them individually.

"People who have never had a bank account often believe that they won't now be able to open one or that hidden charges will make it too expensive. I am here to help people open accounts, complete the direct debit forms and make the right choices."

The Benefits and Banking Project reaches out to 123,000 residents in London and the South East. Find out more about what changes are coming and what choices you have. **Contact Lesley Edwards on 0208 320 3495.**

CHOICE BASED LETTINGS

Greenwich Council has launched a system offering more choice to people registered on their housing list. The 'Choice Based Lettings' scheme allows eligible tenants to apply for a particular home. Available properties will be advertised on a two weekly basis in the Greenwich Times. Applicants may apply for the property of their choice. Current accommodation details can also be found on www.greenwich.gov.uk/homes

All homes are labelled to help customers identify how appropriate they are to their housing needs. Greenwich Council has put in place a number of guidelines to ensure everyone is treated fairly. Before applying, make sure you have the correct application and reference number. While you may apply for as many different properties as you like, a separate application must be submitted each time. The property you are applying for must meet your housing needs. There are three different ways to register your interest in a property:

• telephone 0208 921 4340 - lines are open 24 hours a day, seven days a week, visit www.greenwich.gov.uk/homes

You can also complete and return the coupon in the Greenwich Times. After the closing date the Council will write to the person whose application fits the property and who has been registered the longest. If they do not want the property they have been offered, the Council will contact the next in line. If you are interested in finding out more about the Choice Based Lettings Scheme please contact the Re-housing Team at Gallions.
Telephone 0800 838 481.

GREEN SCENE



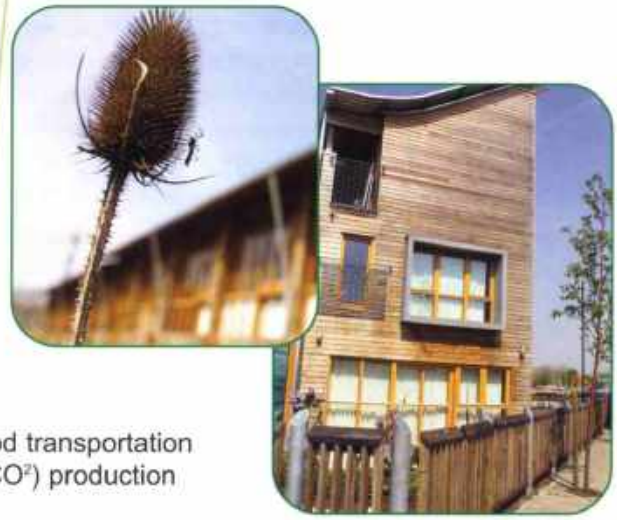
Thinking 'green' is not just about growing our own veggies. It is about looking at our day-to-day activities and finding ways to protect the planet. Today, global warming and climate change are very real issues. Here, Rebecca Miller tells you how you can make a difference.

Water is one of our most precious resources. Without water, crops won't grow, animals have less food and a devastating cycle of destruction is started. Did you know that this part of London is one of the driest regions in the United Kingdom? London is running out of water and the majority of our current supply is pumped from as far away as north Norfolk. This situation is a direct result of global warming – our summers are definitely getting hotter and drier.

Fuel poverty, a relatively new phrase in the environmental language, is where a householder is spending more than 10% of their annual income on heating their home. Currently, nearly 1 in 3 Londoners live in a state of fuel poverty – spending too much on heating bills means that they are in fact using too much fuel. By making your house more energy efficient you can help reduce this dangerously high level of fuel poverty.

Here are some cool tips on how to keep your house warm without hurting the planet

- Low energy lighting bulbs last longer than standard bulbs and use less energy – you won't have to replace these bulbs for a very long time.
- Taking a shower generally uses half the amount of water than a bath. However, an electric power shower will not only use a lot of electricity it will also use twice the amount of water than a standard electric shower – a double whammy for the environment.
- Putting aluminium foil behind the radiators will help keep the heat in – a money saving tip as well as energy saving
- Recycle!
- Don't turn the heating up – just turning your thermostat down by 1°C will save you money.
- If you're making a cup of tea, only fill the kettle for the amount you need to boil.
- Think smart with water and avoid waste.
- Keeping your appliances in 'standby' mode can use up to 80% of the electricity they normally use.
- If you're not in a room, turn the light off.
- Try and buy food products that are grown locally - food transportation is one of the biggest contribution to carbon dioxide (CO^2) production in the UK.



ONE TO ONE CONNECTING THAMESMEAD

Fourteen years ago Steve Boscic and his wife Sally celebrated the birth of their first daughter Katie. Today, Steve is the driving force behind many of Thamesmead's youth community projects. He cares passionately about the environment children grow up in and believes that communication is the key to making things happen.

One thing that makes Steve Boscic stand out from others is that he really understands what makes today's kids tick. He knows how important it is to actually listen to what they are saying. It is this open approach that has helped earn him the respect and trust of Thamesmead's teenagers. Steve believes that simply by asking for something is the best way to find out what's possible and what's not.

"It's all about making the right connections and asking the right people the right questions. Too often opportunities are missed because people don't actually know what's going on in the community. Forging local partnerships is the only way to find solutions that everybody is happy with."

As an active member of the Drug Action Group, the Independent Advisory Board and Neighbourhood Renewal Scheme, Steve has built up a highly effective network of contacts. If he does not know the answer to a particular question he will almost certainly know someone who will. It is this ability to join all the dots together that has helped Steve deliver on so many of his promises. His latest success has been to secure funding for a project to build bleachers at the local football ground. "The kids wanted somewhere that they could hang out like they see in the American movies. I asked and the answer was 'ok'. It was as simple as that." Steve is very keen not to be seen as some kind of local hero and he stresses that he is just one person working with many others. When asked why he devotes so much of his time and energy to youth projects his answer is simple "Because I'm a Dad myself."

Working Partnerships

Steve's commitment to his local community seems to have been passed on to his eldest daughter Katie.

Katie is a member of the Young Life project. Funded by the Children's Society, Young Life involves children between the ages of 5 and 18. Their goal is to assess possible new youth ventures and to apply for funding for those they think are the best ideas. Katie has been on a number of trips around the UK and enjoys being part of a scheme that encourages children to become involved in projects that can make a positive contribution to their lives. Katie says:

"I am learning a lot about organising events as well as how to manage them. It is hard work but a lot of fun as well. My Dad has taught me that it is important to be involved and to try and make a difference."



Leaseholders Line...

A new morning surgery will be held between 10am and 12pm in the Resource Centre on the first Thursday of every month. Appointments will be allocated on a 'first come, first served basis'.

We will contact you shortly with details of our next quarterly Leaseholders Forum - your opportunity to discuss general leaseholder issues.

Axis Europe PLC offers a professional repair service to all leaseholders - 24 hours a day, 365 days a year. AXIS staff know Thamesmead and its properties and offer an efficient service. **For more information call Lynn Miller on 01322 402 136. For details of your repair responsibilities, pick up a leaflet from Gallions Reception.**

The emergency after hours number is

07976 737 117

Areas of Opportunity

Your chance to get involved

Areas of Opportunity is a Programme recently launched by Bexley Council on behalf of the Local Strategic Partnership to tackle disadvantage in Bexley. The Council has carried out various surveys and research projects to find out about the health, education, housing, community safety, social and economic needs of Bexley. We know there are areas in the Borough that residents want to see developed and Areas of Opportunity has been created to address these gaps.

The first area that the programme is targeting is Thamesmead where work began in July 2004. Based on the research and consultation carried out, an action plan has been written to help focus the resources and funds of Areas of Opportunity in your community. A Residents' Forum, has been set up for the Thamesmead area, to give residents a chance to get involved in the programme.
If you are interested in being involved in this forum please contact Sara Mohideen on tel: 020 8303 7777 ex 2871, or email **sara.mohideen@bexley.gov.uk**

For more information about the Areas of Opportunity Programme please visit **www.bexley.gov.uk/areasofopportunity**

Next Neighbourhood Forum for Broadwaters will be held on the 23rd February, at 6.30pm in the village hall.

Football success from Thamesmead



We are the champions. Winning smiles from the victorious team. Trials have already started for this year's London Estates Football League

The London Estates Football League was established to help break down barriers by bringing together young people from different backgrounds and cultures across London. Junior football teams where formed around the capital and the London Estates League kicked off in the summer. On 6th December 2004 the League reached its nail biting climax with the junior versions of Charlton Athletic and West Ham United squaring up to each other. Although the competition was fierce and the commitment rock solid, there could only ever be one winner – Charlton Athletic Community Scheme topped the league with a highly impressive 45 points. While team members were drawn from areas in Bexley, Greenwich, Dartford and Gravesham perhaps the most surprising statistic to emerge from the entire tournament is that 10 of the winning squad come from Thamesmead itself. Such a concentration of talent, however comes as no surprise to Marc Leckie, Bexley Positive Futures Officer.

"Upon starting work in Thamesmead some 18 months ago, it was clear that there is a huge pool of footballing talent in the area as yet untapped. There are a number of young people, who with continued commitment and hard work, will go far in the game."



GALLIONS FREEPHONE 0800 83 84 81

VICTIM SUPPORT

Most politicians agree that tackling crime is one of today's most challenging areas. Every day there are reports on new initiatives and schemes to address the problems. But what happens to the victim? Who addresses their problems? Working in partnership with Greenwich and Bexley Councils, Gallions Housing Association has launched a Thamesmead Victim Support scheme.



Victim Support is a national charity that is run by fully trained volunteers. The services we offer are free and available to everyone. An independent body, victims and witnesses may contact us directly. The Witness Service provides on-going assistance throughout the court procedure. Even when the case is over we are happy to offer help and advice when necessary. Whether emotional support or practical help is needed– we have the skills to provide both. Gallions runs a drop-in centre every Wednesday morning at the Tenant Resource Centre from 9.30am to 12pm.

CONTACT DETAILS

Victim Support Bexley: 0208 303 1248 or vsbexley@aol.com
Victim Support Greenwich: 0208 854 1113 or info@vs-greenwich.org.uk

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾。請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phòng bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐

(please tick one)

Name: _____

Address: _____

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Return to: Joy McKee, Translation Requests, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

For all enquiries please contact the
Customer Response Centre
0800 83 84 81
It's a freeephone number that you can use to book services, repairs or for any other enquiries.

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION